

Discovering Hidden Community Leaders

Participant Information Sheet (PIS)

Researcher's name: Lyndsey Ballantyne, Oscar Seip, Cassandra Gould Van Praag, Emma Karoune
ERGO number: ERGO/FEPS/111889
Version number and date: Version 1, March 2026

This section provides a brief overview of the key points to help you decide whether you would like to participate. More detailed information is provided in the sections that follow.

- We invite you to take part in our research study. Before you decide, please take time to read this information. It explains why we are doing the study and what it will involve.
- If anything is unclear or if you have any questions, please ask.
- You can talk to someone you trust before you decide. It's entirely your choice whether to take part.
- If you decide to take part, you will be asked to sign a consent form.

What is the study about?

Many people working in UK digital research carry out Research Community Management (RCM) activities, such as coordinating communities of practice or supporting open-source projects. This study aims to better understand the scope and value of this work, and how a lack of formal recognition affects career development and leadership opportunities.

Why does it matter?

Findings from this study will help extend the DIRECT Framework for Research Technical Professionals (RTPs) and inform the design of future research activities. Ultimately, this work aims to support better recognition and career pathways for those doing vital community-building work across the UK research landscape.

Who is running the study?

The Discovering Hidden Community Leaders project is a collaboration between the Universities of Southampton and Manchester, the Software Sustainability Institute (SSI), and the Research Community Management Cooperative (RCM Cooperative). You will interact with members of the project team, specifically the work package leads for whichever activity you are invited to take part in.

What would participation involve?

Depending on which part of the study you are invited to join, you may be asked to provide professional information to contribute to a map of the RCM landscape (WP1) and additionally take part in a one-to-one online interview about your experiences of RCM activities (WP2). Interviews will be conducted via MS Teams and will be recorded for the purposes of generating transcripts for thematic analysis. Interview recordings and transcriptions will be retained and deleted in accordance with the University of Southampton's Research Data Management Policy.

What happens to your data?

Your data will be handled and stored in accordance with the University of Southampton's data protection policy and UK GDPR.

Landscape mapping data from WP1 will be used to create (1) an internal mapping to report on and evaluate the SSI Fellowship Programme, mentor matching, and collaboration; and (2) an external public mapping to foster collaboration and knowledge exchange. You can consent to either the internal mapping or both the internal and public mapping in the consent form. Both mappings will be shared with named project members. The public mapping will be published with all contact information removed. The data of the public mapping will also be shared with members of the RCM Cooperative and may be used for future activities, including extended landscape mapping and research projects. Your contact details will be retained and deleted in accordance with the University of Southampton's Research Data Management Policy. .

Interview data from WP2 will be recorded for the purpose of generating transcriptions for thematic analysis. This data will be shared with members of the research team. Interview recordings and transcriptions will be retained and deleted in accordance with the University of Southampton's Research Data Management Policy.

Payment or reimbursement

There is no payment or reimbursement for taking part in this study.

What is the research about?

Across the UK's Digital Research Technical Professional (dRTP) landscape, many individuals informally undertake Research Community Management (RCM) activities, such as coordinating open-source contributions and sustaining communities of practice, without formal recognition, support, or inclusion in job descriptions. This lack of visibility and institutional backing creates a fragile and uneven foundation for community leadership, limiting incentives and career development opportunities for those performing this vital work.

This project seeks to build a deeper understanding of the scope, value, and impact of RCM within the research ecosystem. Through landscape mapping and qualitative interviews with RTPs engaged in RCM activities, we will identify key organisations, communities and competencies involved in RCM activities and explore how the absence of formalisation affects leadership and progression. Findings will extend the DIRECT Framework, particularly its Community and Outreach competencies, and inform the design of a statistically robust, construct-validated survey targeting the wider UK RTP community.

The project is a collaboration between the Universities of Southampton (UoS) and Manchester (UoM), the Software Sustainability Institute (SSI), and the Research Community Management Cooperative (RCM Cooperative). The project is supported by the DisCourSE project, which aims to develop a community of leaders in the dRTP space.

WP1 Landscape Mapping is co-led by Emma Karoune (RCM Cooperative) and Oscar Seip (UoM/SSI).

WP2 Qualitative Interviews is co-led by Cassandra Gould Van Praag (RCM Cooperative) and Lyndsey Ballantyne (UoS/SSI).

This research project has been reviewed and approved by Faculty Research Ethics Committees and Research Ethics and Governance office, University of Southampton [APPROVAL REFERENCE NUMBER TO BE ADDED].

Why have I been asked to take part?

You are being invited to take part because you are a Research Technical Professional who is engaged in, or has experience of, Research Community Management activities within the UK digital research landscape.

For this phase of the project, we are specifically inviting participation from the Software Sustainability Institute and Society of Research Software Engineering communities, and close collaborators.

What will happen to me if I take part?

Participation in this study involves one or both of the following activities:

WP1: Landscape Mapping

You will be asked to provide professional information to help map the landscape of RCM activity across the UK dRTP community. This will involve completing a short survey including providing contact and professional details.

WP2: Qualitative Interviews

You will be invited to take part in a one-to-one qualitative interview with a member of the research team. The interview will explore your experiences of RCM activities, the value and impact of this work, and how the absence of formalisation affects leadership and career progression.

Interviews will be conducted online via MS Teams. Interviews will be recorded by MS Teams for purposes of generating a transcript using Microsoft's own built-in Automated Speech Recognition (ASR) technology, powered by Microsoft Azure Cognitive Services. The researcher might also take written notes during the interview.

There will be no follow-up sessions required, though a summary of findings may be shared with participants at the end of the project if you wish to receive it. The overall research project is expected to run until July 2026.

Are there any benefits in my taking part?

There is no direct personal benefit to you from participating in this study, and you will not receive any reimbursement for your time. However, your contribution will help to build a better understanding of the scope and value of RCM work, and may ultimately support better recognition, career development, and institutional support for RTPs performing these activities across the UK.

Findings will be used to extend the DIRECT Framework and inform the design of future (research) activities, contributing to improvements in the wider dRTP community.

Are there any risks involved?

We do not anticipate any significant risks from participating in this study. The interview topics relate to your professional experiences and the nature of your work, which raise reflections about lack of recognition or career challenges.

If at any point you feel uncomfortable during the interview, you are free to decline to answer any question or to end your participation without giving a reason. During interview you will be asked not to share any names of other individuals or sensitive data relating to individuals or organisations. If any sensitive details are disclosed during the interview, they will be deidentified and/or generalised during analysis.

What data will be collected?

The following data will be collected during this study:

WP1 – Landscape mapping

Professional and contact information (e.g. name, institutional affiliation, role, communities you engage with or support, RCM activities you undertake, professional web profile links). No protected category information will be collected. Your contact details will not be included in the public version of the map, should you consent to be included in that.

WP2 – Qualitative interviews

Recording and automated transcript of interview by MS Teams. Written notes taken by the researcher during your interview, capturing your responses to questions about your RCM experiences. We are not intending to collect data around protected characteristics. If these are incidentally exposed, they will be considered in the analysis if they are relevant to the research objectives.

Data for both WP1 and WP2 will be collected by members of the research team and stored securely on University of Southampton or SharePoint/OneDrive servers. WP1 data will additionally be processed for visualisation using Kumu.io, which uses AWS servers. Kumu's privacy policy (<https://kumu.io/security>) ensures that this data will not be accessed by their team or third parties without prior consent.

How will my information and personal details be protected?

- Your participation and the information we collect about you during the research will be kept strictly confidential during the study.
- Only the research team and approved staff from the University of Southampton may see your data to help monitor the study. They may also check the study to make sure it complies with research regulations.
- People from regulatory organisations (who make sure the study follows proper rules) might also need access to your data.
- Everyone who sees your information is required to keep it confidential.
- Data collected as part of this study will be handled and stored in accordance with the University of Southampton's data protection policy. Data from the landscape mapping and qualitative interviews will be shared with named project members of the Discovering Hidden Community Leaders project from the Universities of Southampton and Manchester, the Software Sustainability Institute, and the RCM Cooperative.
- Landscape mapping data will be used to report on the SSI Fellowship Programme to other staff members, funders, the Advisory Board, and publicly via the SSI website, as well as to evaluate and improve promotional and recruitment strategies for the Fellowship Programme.
- Data from the public version of the landscape mapping will be shared with the RCM Cooperative, who may use it as the basis for future mapping and research projects. Participants have the option to opt out of the public version and sharing their data with the RCM Cooperative.
- A public version of the landscape mapping data will additionally be published. However, any contact information will be removed before publication to protect participants' privacy.
- All data will be stored securely on University of Southampton servers and/or SharePoint/OneDrive, which are managed under the governance of the University of Southampton Research Data Management Policy. Only authorised users can access data stored on these systems.
- Your contact details will be held securely with the internal mapping data, but separately from the interview research data for the duration of the project.
- Research data will be retained for a minimum of 10 years from the end of the study, in accordance with the University of Southampton's Research Data Management Policy, after which it will be securely deleted or anonymised for archival.

Do I have to take part?

- No, it is entirely up to you to decide whether to take part. If you decide to take part, you will need to indicate consent to show you have agreed to take part.
- To indicate your interest in taking part, please contact the research team (see contact details below).

What happens if I change my mind?

- You have the right to change your mind and are free to withdraw at any time without giving a reason. You can do so by contacting the research team (see contact details below).
- You can withdraw any information you have shared up until the end date of the project in July 2026. If you choose to leave the study, we will keep the information already collected, but only to help meet the study's goals, in accordance with the GDPR exemption for research.

What will happen to the results of the research?

- Reports and publications will not directly identify you without your specific consent.
- Findings will be written up for academic publication and may be shared via the research organisation's websites, conference presentations, and other public channels.
- If you would like to receive a summary of the findings at the end of the project, please let the research team know.

Where can I get more information?

If you have any questions about the study, please contact the research team:

- Lyndsey Ballantyne (lead): L.Ballantyne@soton.ac.uk
- Oscar Seip (co-lead): oscar.seip@manchester.ac.uk
- Emma Karoune (co-lead): emma.karoune@rcmcooperative.com
- Cassandra Gould van Praag (co-lead): cassandra.gouldvanpraag@rcmcooperative.com

What happens if there is a problem?

- If you are concerned or unhappy about any part of the study, please contact the researchers. They will do their best to answer your questions.
- If you remain unhappy or have a complaint about any part of this study, please contact the Head of Research Ethics and Governance (023 8059 5058, rgoinfo@soton.ac.uk), University of Southampton.

Data Protection Privacy Notice

This Participant Information Sheet tells you what data will be collected for this project and whether this includes any personal data. Please ask the research team if you have any questions or are unclear what data is being collected about you.

How will we use information about you?

Any personal data we collect in this study will be used only for the purposes of carrying out our research. Contact details will not be retained beyond the end of the study or used for future studies. Your personal data will be handled according to the University's relevant policies.

The University of Southampton is the 'Data Controller' for the personal information we collect from you for this research project.

Information that may identify you, such as name, job role, contact details, and institutional affiliation, will be used to carry out the research or to check your records to make sure that the research is being done properly. Where possible, your data will be pseudonymised so that people who do not need to know who you are will not be able to see your name or contact details.

We will keep all information about you safe and secure.

Once the study is finished, your identifiable contact information will be deleted. Anonymised research data will be retained for a minimum of 10 years from the end of the study, in accordance with the University of Southampton Research Data Management Policy.

We will write our reports in a way that no-one can work out that you took part in the study.

To safeguard your rights, we will use the minimum personal data necessary to achieve our research study objectives. Your data protection rights – such as to access, change, or transfer such information – may be limited, however, in order for the research output to be reliable and accurate. The University will not do anything with your personal data that you would not reasonably expect. We will keep all information about you safe and secure.

What are your choices about how your information is used?

- You can stop being part of the study at any time, without giving a reason, but we will keep all anonymised information about you that we already have.

- We need to manage your records in specific ways for the research to be reliable. This means that we won't be able to let you see or change the data we hold about you.

Where can you find out more about how your information is used?

You can find out more about how we use your information:

- by sending an email to University's Data Protection Officer (data.protection@soton.ac.uk).
- by asking one of the research team or from our [general privacy policy](#).
- by sending an email to [email], or by ringing us on [phone number].

How long we keep your data?

Research data will be retained for a minimum of 10 years from the end of the study, in accordance with the University of Southampton's Research Data Management Policy, after which it will be securely deleted or anonymised for archival.

Please visit for more information: <https://www.southampton.ac.uk/about/governance/regulations-policies/policies/research-data-management>

Thank you for taking the time to read the information sheet and considering taking part in the research.